



Remember what you're good at!

Bruce Baxter

Welcome

- Here is what got me thinking about this.
- I'm a car guy, and while I do most of the work myself, I sometimes need to use the local mechanic.
- So, Let me tell you the story



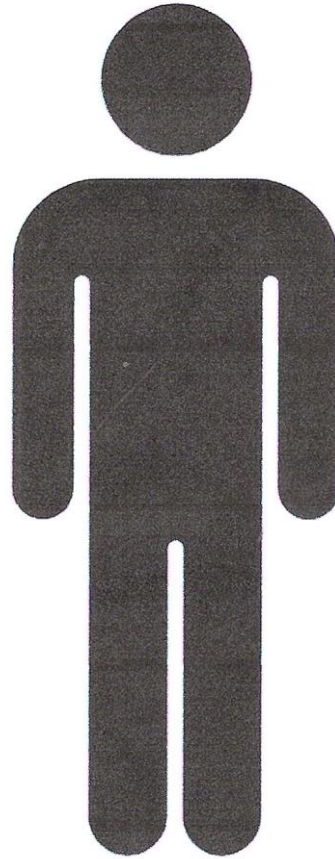
- This sounds familiar and is commonplace in many industries including the aviation industry.
- The following is intended to initiate a thought process within your business.
- While it is mainly aimed at the privately owned maintenance facility, several corporate organisations can benefit from this insight.

- I not only travel around but also have contact with People around the world and when I ask them how their business is going there is always the common answer
- it is extremely difficult to get employees and the ones we can get are either not very good or want too much money.
- Before we deal with that, let us step back a few years. Let's look at the business structure.

Typical business structure

- Most avionics maintenance shops are started by a person who is extremely good at what they do.
- So, Let's call this guy Bob.
- Bob leaves his current employer to start his own facility.
- Bob is now a business owner, a one-man band, and he now has the following duties.

Meet BOB



As a Business owner, what is Bob's job description include

- **General Manager**
- **Technician**
- **Installer**
- **Salesman**
- **Storeman**
- **Receipt and despatch clerk**
- **Invoice clerk**

- **Debt collector**
- **Bill payer**
- **Librarian**
- **Quality Manager**
- **Regulator liaison**
- **Etc.**

- This doesn't phase Bob because he is the best avionics guy around, that's why he started his own business.
- So, the initial quality output from Bob's business is 100%.
- Because Bob is so good some of his ex-employers' customers follow him and pretty soon word of mouth has his business going forward with new customers.
- With absolute determination Bob tries his best to handle the increased workload by himself

Now here is where one of two things can happen, he can either,

1. Try and handle the increased workload, but if he can't then the Business has the potential for failure.

OR

2. He decides to employ another worker to share the workload, and this should provide the business with the best chance to move forward and survive.

OK, Bobs clever and decides on option 2.

- Bob advertises for an avionics employee and two people apply, one is from the Airlines and is fully licenced including Several MA's and the other applicant has done a pre-vocation avionics course and is seeking an apprenticeship.
- The Airline guy demands a salary that is almost more than the small company turnover and as we know Bob needs help, so he takes on the apprentice.

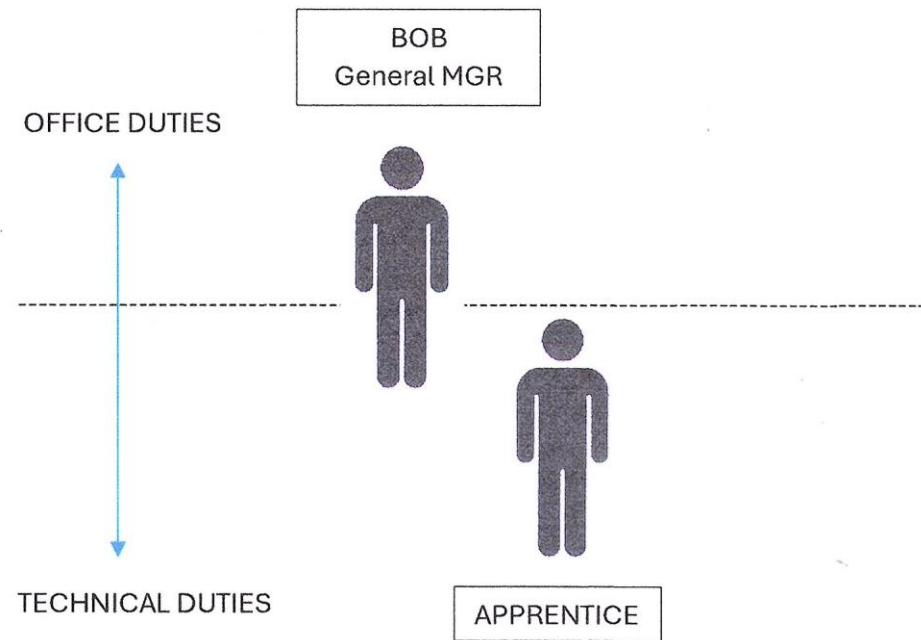
Bob's Business

- Apprenticeships provide hands-on learning experiences for novices under the guidance of skilled professionals.
- In Bob's business, the apprentice is expected to learn the ropes, develop skills, and contribute to productivity.
- Ideally, this should be a mutually beneficial relationship.
- however

- Bob is responsible for direct management and training of his apprentice.
- He also has significant office work responsibilities that demand his attention.
- Balancing these roles is challenging and impacts business quality.

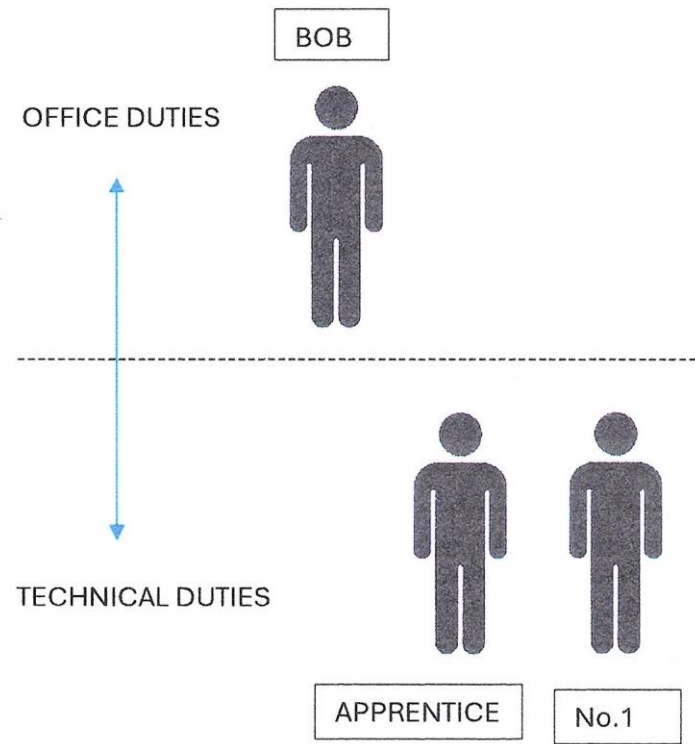
Impact on quality

- Quality of work reflects the skills and dedication of the workforce.
- When Bob is preoccupied with office duties, the apprentice manages tasks independently.
- Limited experience of the apprentice results in errors and inefficiencies.
- Business quality drops to match the apprentice's level of expertise.



- Time marches on and Bob continues to struggle just like the mechanic, and now he is willing to pay more money to get the right guy, so he continues to advertise everywhere he can.
 - Wanted qualified Aircraft Maintenance Engineer, Avionics category. Good conditions, excellent remuneration.
- Luck has it that he gets a really great person apply for the job and he employs him.

- AT LAST, Bob has a great technical licenced guy, the Apprentice is learning quicker, and the Business is humming along.



- OK, let's fast forward to today.
- Bob has 5 Staff.

Bob's business today

- Bob has a ton of work and needs more people, but Bob still can't get qualified technical people to fill the positions that he wants.
- Now it is time to look at the business structure.
- What do Bob and the other five people do in the business.

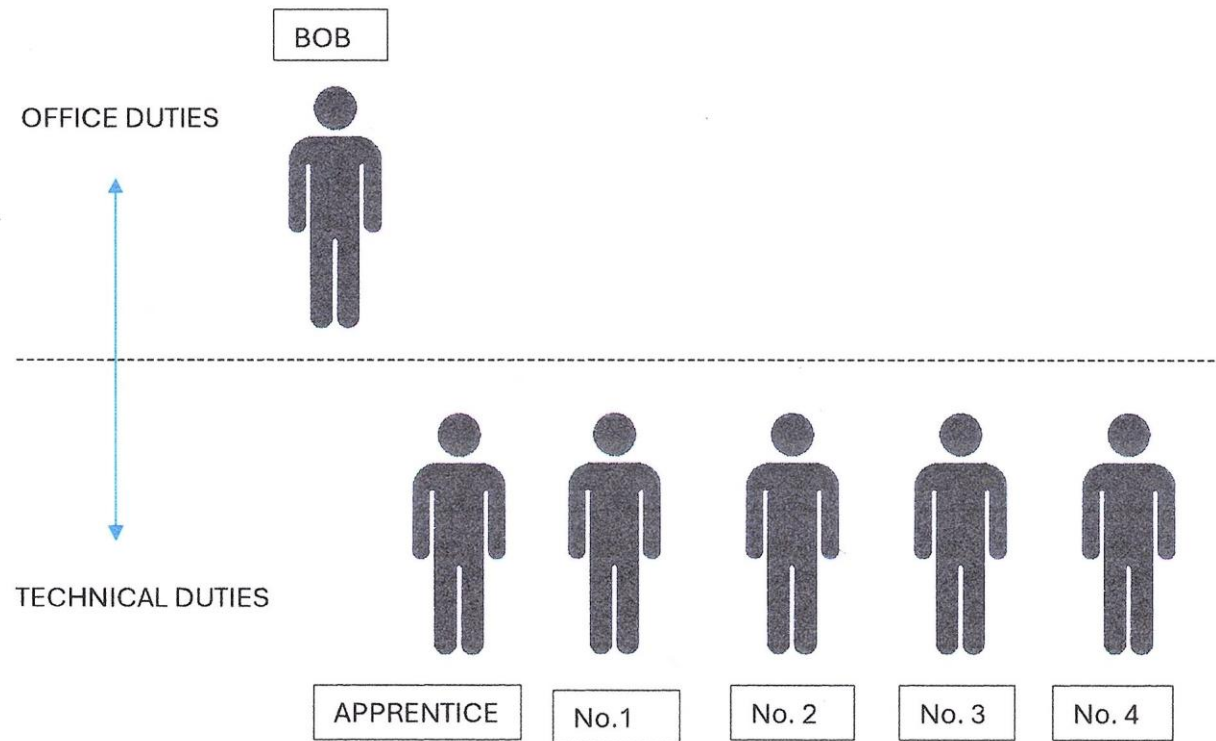
Bob's position

- General Manager, Salesman, Storeman, Receipt and despatch clerk, Invoice clerk, Debt collector, Bill payer, Librarian, Payroll clerk, Etc.
- Same as before, but the workload has increased to a point that Bob had to delegate the
- Technician,
- Installer,
- Quality Manager and Regulator liaison duties to other staff members.

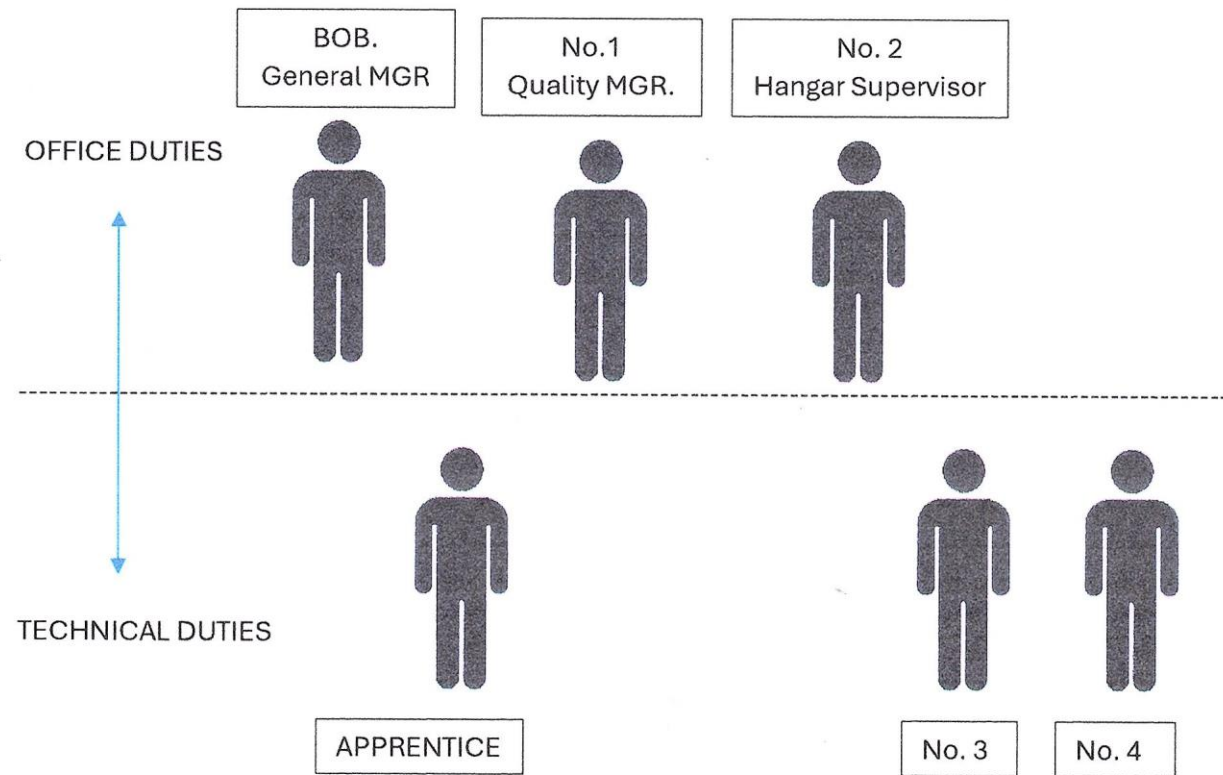
Examples only

- Bob's fictitious business is only here as an example, your business will probably have different names and structure, but the message is still the same.

You probably expect Bob's Business structure to look something like this like this:



In Actual fact, it might look more like this



Why?

- Let us dig a little deeper and look at the duties of them all.
- First, BOB
- Bob has so much office duties that he does absolutely no technical work

No.1 Tech.

Because Bob has a couple of great staff now, he elevates them to what he considers to be higher duties.

No. 1 Tech – now has an office and is the

- Quality control manager,
- Regulatory Compliance,
- CASA/FAA liaison and
- Does little or no technical work. (time Permitting)

No.2 Tech.

No.2 Tech – Might have an office or a dedicated desk and is the

- Workshop / Hangar Supervisor,
- Overseeing and fault-finding installations and Maintenance,
- Document/Data control (amendments etc.)
- Assisting with System planning and
- a small amount of technical work, (time permitting).

No. 3 and 4 Tech plus 1 Apprentice

- These less experienced staff members are now doing almost all the income generating work however they can't reach maximum efficiency as their time is shared with training and overseeing the Apprentice.
- So, what does Bob do next.
- He Advertises for staff again
 - Wanted qualified Aircraft Maintenance Engineer, Avionics category. Good conditions, excellent remuneration. Etc. etc.
- Once again nobody applies for the position that is sufficiently qualified.

- **Now we get to the crux of the problem,**
- **Bob's most experienced staff, including Bob himself are not necessarily employed in the areas that provide the best outcome for the business.**
- **While all these scenarios do not always seem apparent in your business, I'm sure that you can all identify some similar experiences.**

- **Which brings me to**

Remember what you're good at

- OR to put it simply
- Maximizing use of resources

- **Remember, as the business owner and originator, you are the most qualified person in your business**
- **(or at least you think you are)**
- **yet you do no Technical tasks.**
- **Also Remember, You have elevated you're most experienced staff to various non-technical positions.**
- **And**
- **you are having trouble finding affordable qualified staff to replace you all.**

- **How did we get to this, well it's simple.**
- **We have created an illusion, it's all smoke and mirrors**



- **It is our fault.**
- **We have created the illusion that to be elevated to a non-Technical position like Quality Manager is a promotion.**
- **And we have done this simply by adding the Title – Manager.**
- **Not all positions need to be managers.**
- **How would that position be perceived if was called Quality Officer?**

- **What about Job coordinator instead of Workshop Supervisor**
- **Think about some of the other titles you use in your business that give the perception of increased importance.**

- **There are many other ways of rewarding good staff other than giving them a title.**
- **Here's a couple,**
- **Additional Leave,**
- **Bonus schemes.**

- What you effectively have is

- **All the right people in all the wrong places**

Examples only

- **Let us look at these three examples in a bit more detail.**
- **1. Managing Director**
- **2. Quality Officer**
- **And**
- **3. Job Coordinator**

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- Managing Director (Bob)
- Duties
- General Manager, Salesman, Storeman, Receipt and despatch clerk, Invoice clerk, Debt collector, Bill payer, Librarian, Payroll clerk, Etc.
- NOW
- Look at the duties carried out by Bob and determine which duties are not required to be performed by a qualified Avionics person or the owner of the business.
- ~~General Manager, Salesman, Storeman, Receipt and despatch clerk, Invoice clerk, Debt collector, Bill payer, Librarian, Payroll clerk, Etc.~~

Remember what you're good at

- Now Bob, the best technical guy in the business, has time to do technical, income earning work.
- But what happens to the other duties?
- Well,
- you hire a non-technical “Business Administrator”

- **Business Administrator (not Manager)**
- **Easier to get**
- **Don't require any more business qualifications than Bob had (which more than likely is none).**
- **Someone with office experience or someone with a good high school report could possibly work. (Math's and English)**
- **a lot less money than a technically qualified person.**

- **Remember, it's BOB's business and he still makes all the Business decisions.**

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- **Quality Manager**
- **Hire a Quality officer to free up the No.1 Technical person to do more technical work.**
- **Easier to get**
- **Don't hire a professional Quality person, within our business you probably only need a good high school (Senior) grade.**
- **But spend a once only 1 to 2 thousand Dollars and send them to a couple of ISO 9000 courses. (you will save that in wages)**

- **My suggestion for training would be**
- **1. Documenting a Quality System**
- **and**
- **2. Auditing a Quality System.**
- **You have now regained a technical person when there are none available.**
- **Other than the initial training, a lot less money than a technically qualified person.**

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Workshop/Hangar Supervisor.

This one is a bit more difficult as a certain level of Technical understanding is required.

**Remember our aim is to get additional technical people doing hands on work
So how do we free up the position of Workshop/Hangar Supervisor**

Well firstly, lets call the position “Job Controller”

Secondly, let us look at what we want the job controller to do.

- **Easy part (requires some technical understanding of the job)**
- **Prioritizing jobs**
- **Ensure all staff are engaged in productive jobs**
- **Ensuring all parts and equipment are available to complete the job**
- **Ensuring that suitably qualified staff are assigned to a particular job**

- **Harder part (requires a much higher level of technical knowledge)**
- **Offer technical assistance when required**

I have intentionally included this position in our discussion to demonstrate that not every position can be filled by a non-technical employee.

We still need that Technical guy providing the oversight.

However, the title Supervisor tends to suggest that no hands-on work shall take place only supervision of others as the dictionary says;

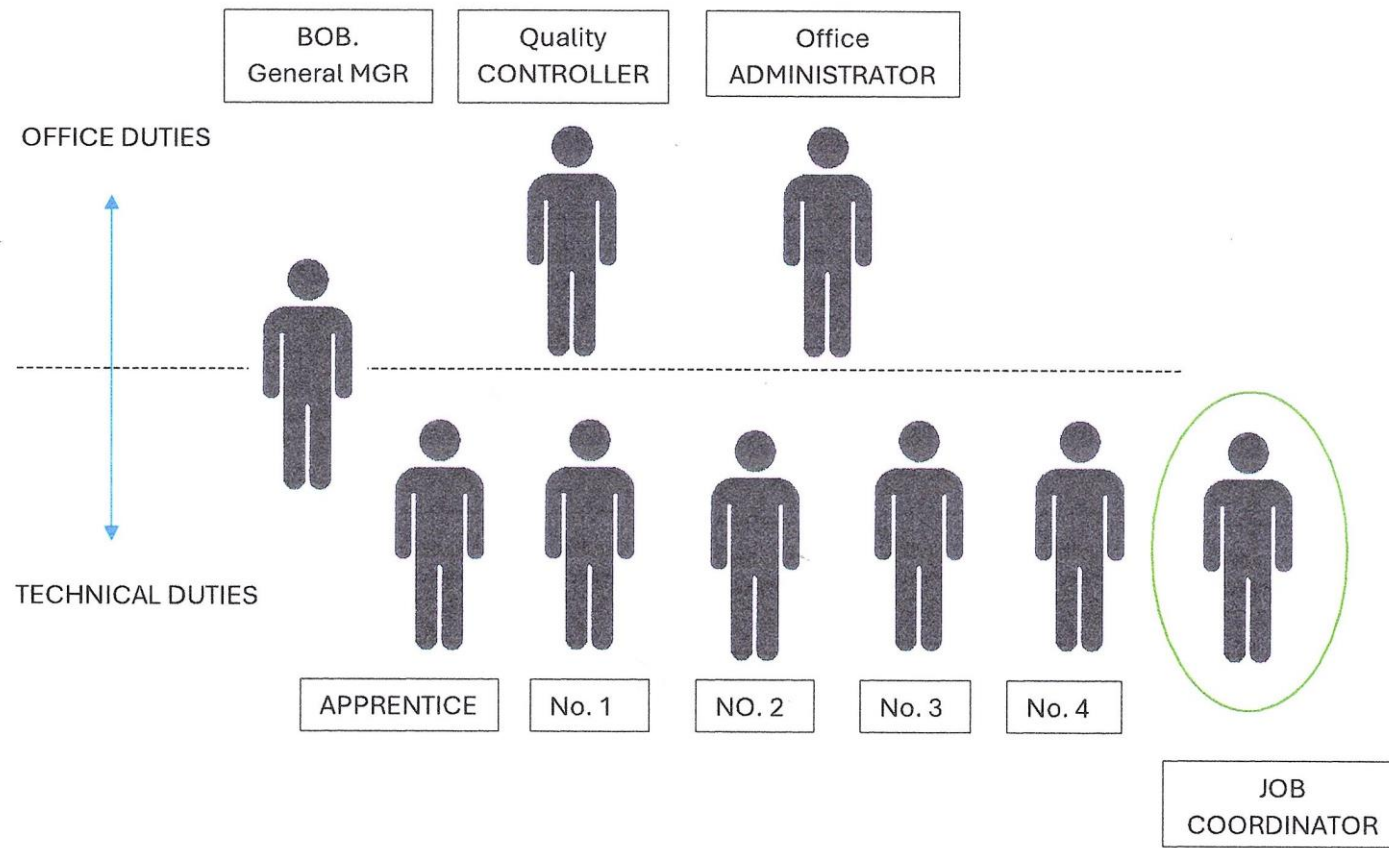
“a person who is in charge of a group of people or an area of work and who makes sure that the work is done correctly and according to the rules”

- **Things you can do**
- **Give the Supervisor position another name that is less likely to have someone sitting around. (Coordinator, Controller)**
- **Employ a retired avionics maintenance person looking to return to the workforce for some extra income**
- **or**
- **A qualified avionics maintenance person that has had an injury that prevents them from doing some, or all, of the hands-on work**

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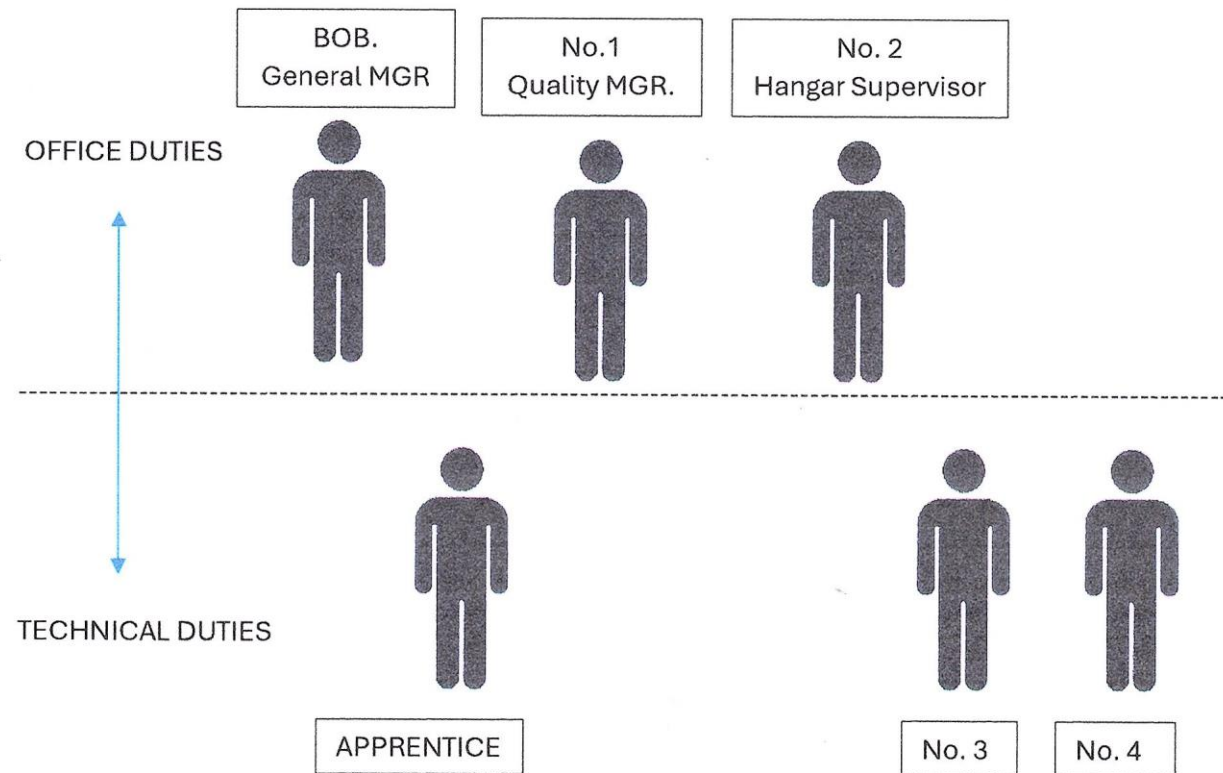
- **So how did Bob come out of this.**
- **1. Bob hired two Non-Technical staff for the same or less cost than 1 Licensed avionics person**
- **2. Bob regained 1 and ½ licensed technical people**
- **3. Bob is advertising for EX avionics technicians for the position of Job co-Ordinator.**

BOB'S Business now



- **So, with a little bit of our own magic, we have solved Bob's staff issues.**
- **All in all, a good outcome for Bob.**
- **But what about you?**

CAUTION



Remember what you're good at

I hope this has inspired you to look at you're own staffing and employment options and not get fixated on employing qualified Maintenance people when you could possibly make some minor changes and employ non-technical people to free up the Technical staff you already have.

THANK YOU